

in the Priest's Code is an elaborate affair and not historical, but E knows of an **מוֹעֵד אֱהָל**, tells us of its erection, and gives its name (Ex. 33⁷⁻¹¹), and also, as has been shown above, brings Miriam in close connection with it. In view of these facts, it is safe to say that the passages in Exodus and Samuel, though late themselves, are in perfect harmony with, and probably embody, an ancient tradition according to which, in early times, women held some official position in the sanctuary of Jahveh.

A side light upon woman's official position in the Jahveh cult comes to us also from the references in the Old Testament to the women singers. There are four distinct classes of these, one of which, the **שָׂרוֹת**, mentioned in passages like 2 S. 19³⁵ Jer. 31⁴ Ec. 2⁸ and Is. 23¹⁶, sang evidently only for social amusement, and may here be passed by with the mere mention. The other three classes will find the simplest explanation when considered in their relation to the religious cult.

(1) *The מְקַנְנֹת who chant the קִנּוֹת*. — Their official relation to, and prominence in, the cult of the dead have been considered above. See p. 137.

(2) The **מְבַשֶּׁרֶת**, *εὐαγγελιζομένη*, is mentioned by that name only in Ps. 68¹²⁽¹¹⁾, and the term is also applied to Jerusalem in Is. 40⁹; but the function of the **מְבַשֶּׁרֶת**, to announce and celebrate a victory by vocal and instrumental music and dances, finds frequent mention in the Old Testament (Ex. 15²⁰ Ju. 5¹ 11³⁴ 1 S. 18⁶ Ps. 68²⁶⁽²⁵⁾; cf. also 2 S. 1²⁰). That these choral dances were at least of a semi-religious character will scarcely admit of doubt. These were the "wars of Jahveh," and He Himself is **יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת**: the celebration of victory⁵⁶ must have partaken of a religious character. This becomes all the more evident from the religious element contained in some of these songs preserved to us (see Ex. 15²¹ Ju. 5^{3ff.} Ps. 68 Judith 15^{12ff.} 16^{1f.}). These facts have naturally enough led some to suppose that the particular service that the women according to Ex. 38⁸ and 1 S. 2²² rendered was the sacred choral dances. It is very probable that the term **צָבָא** may cover, but there is no reason to suppose that it exhausts, this part of woman's service.

(3) *Women Singers in the Temple Choir*. — Neh. 7⁶⁷ and the parallel passage in Ezra 2⁶⁵ furnish a more direct reference to woman's participation in public religious song. In Neh. 7⁶⁷, a register which has every appearance of having been drawn up under Zerubbabel

⁵⁶ "The Hebrew phrase for opening war is 'to consecrate war' (**קָדַשׁ מִלְחָמָה**), and warriors are consecrated persons." — W. R. Smith, *Rel. of Sem.*, p. 383.